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xi

by jeserai

Summary

Adora's laugh is quiet, but genuine. She props herself up on an elbow to look down at Catra, and her gaze is serious. "You'd find me, wouldn't you? In our next life?"

Notes

the day i ever finish a fic its over for yall

See the end of the work for more notes

1.

"When I thought I was going to die," Adora says, "it was you that I thought about, not anyone else. Every time my phone lit up, I wanted it to be because of you. But...we're still - I don't want to take advantage of you, or you of me. So," Adora takes both of Catra's hands in hers, touching her fully for the first time in days, "in a year from now, when we've settled everything, I am going to ask you out."

Catra's breath very audibly catches in her throat, and she can't help the startled laugh that stutters out. Adora feels more pleased with herself than she should for such a simple thing, to make Catra laugh, to fluster her instead of being the one that is always flustered. "This is your second confession today, you know that?"

And that's not exactly what Adora was expecting Catra to say, but - that's just Catra. "Second of many," is all she says, even though there is *so* much she wants to say.

"You've always been so direct...it's-"

"Bad?"

Catra takes a long few moments to respond, glancing down before shaking her head. "It's not bad, just...I'm a little taken aback."

They're still holding hands. "It's just easy with you." *It always has been.*

"I'm wondering," Catra drawls, putting up that fearless, careless facade again, "if you'll remember this in a year."

She's still letting Adora hold her hands, and she isn't pulling away. And that's more than enough, for now.

"I guess we'll have to see."

Catra's cheshire grin is somehow even lazier, even softer. "I guess we will."

2.

When they were little, Adora's bed felt so big, even when Adora lay stretched out and spread eagled. Catra could do the same if she wanted, but (like a kitten, Adora always teases) she always lays curled in a tiny, tiny ball.

Adora's bed is equally Catra's. In the summers, the days are all the same, with Catra waking up to Adora's quiet breaths ruffling her hair, and then staying still and quiet until Adora eventually wakens. Then it's breakfast and play outside and play inside and lunch and dinner, and more play until finally - bed. Always, always together.

And all through the years, as everything changes between them, Adora's bed stays the same. Catra always curls up on the left side, closest to the wall, and Adora always stretches out next to her on the right.

3.

"I feel like..." Adora chews at her lip, avoiding Catra's gaze as she tries to think of what to say. "A deep sense of foreboding. Like...something bad is going to happen. To me. And I just hope you know that I really did love you-"

"What are you talking about? Stop talking to me like it's our last time."

"I just-"

"You *can't* die," (Catra's voice breaks on the word, and Adora glances up, startled) "before me. I have never known a world

without you, Adora. I was born into this world with you already in it, so you have to-"

Adora takes both of Catra's hands in hers, trying in her own way to soothe her; all Catra does is stare at her, gaze both intense and sad. "After me," Catra finally manages to say, "you have to die after me so my entire life on this earth would have been with you. I will have never known an existance without you, and I hope I never will. Please stay with me, Adora."

And there are so many things that Adora wants to say, but there is a lump in her throat that she just can't swallow around, and all she can say is, "Always."

4.

For as long as Adora has known, Catra has been by her side.

There are pictures of them sleeping in the same crib, with Adora clinging to Catra even in sleep, or Catra curling up in a little ball next to Adora, stretched out and mouth hung open. (Adora had cried and cried until Catra was put *right* next to her for naptime, apparently.)

And then there are so many memories - their friendship is built on scrapes and cuts, shared lunches and bare feet on the pavement, sledding and swimming and naps and staying up together until they both fall asleep.

What is important is that they are always, always together. Even in fifth grade, when they're put in separate homerooms, Adora always waits by Catra's classroom door so they can go to recess together. And in the ninth grade, when they have different lunch times, Catra sneaks out of class whenever she can just to spend five or ten minutes with Adora at lunch.

5.

Princess Adora is the most infuriating person Catra has ever met, and maybe she is just a little bit in love with her.

Catra is assigned to Adora when they are both thirteen, when Catra finally finishes basic training, but they've known each other for years upon years. In fact, as most of the other knights say, it had been Princess Adora that had chosen Catra above any other knight.

And Catra is proud, at first. She is the personal guard of the Crown Princess, staying by her side day and night instead of doing drilils upon drills and spars upon spars. She is *special,* she is *wanted,* she is *needed.*

But Princess Adora is...well.

She is sweet, and bright, and her smile is soft.

She tries for perfection in everything she does, and she is kind to everyone that she meets. Which is really fucking exasperating, if Catra is being honest. And that's not just because she wants Adora's time for herself, it's just - she's sick of following her around everywhere all the time.

6.

"Hey, *Adora*," Catra says through a laugh. She keeps her hands on Adora's waist (tiny, tiny) until she straightens, and then for a moment longer. "How's it hanging?"

Even though Catra can't see Adora's face, she can tell that the Princess is frowning - and when she turns, she's right. Adora is trying her hardest to scowl, but it melts into a soft smile when she meets Catra's gaze.

"Thank you, Catra. Though - how did you know where....?"

"Really, Adora? I've been your personal knight for how many years? I *know* you. *And* I know that you've been sneaking out for the past few months."

(At that, Adora freezes, clearly surprised, almost a little fearful.)

"Anyway, I'm kind of hurt that you never asked me for help with your...excursions, princess."

"Ugh, you would've just told my parents."

"Oh, *ouch.* I'm hurt."

"Good."

"I guess maybe I *will* do my duty - you know, as your personal guard - and tell-"

"No!" Adora grabs Catra's wrist, and her hand is so warm, and *soft...*

"Alright, you got me, princess. So where are we going?"

"You won't tell *anyone,*" Adora says. Her blue eyes are almost gray, and for the millionth time, Catra can't help the way her gaze is tugged from Adora's eyes to her lips.

"Your word is my command, princess."

Adora keeps hold of her wrist for a moment longer, then nods. "I've been training," she admits, "or trying to."

"Training."

"Yes, training. You always say I'm helpless, and-"

"And I am here to protect you. That is my job, my life's purpose."

Adora glances away, and she draws a part of her - that bright spark that she only lets out when it's just the two of them - back into herself. "Yes, I know."

"Hey. Adora, *Adora.*" Catra cups Adora's face in her hands, forcing their gazes to meet. "I just want you to be safe, okay?"

"I know that, I just...I don't want to be so weak. I don't want you to have to take care of me all the time."

"Who else is gonna do that, dumbass? For one, I don't think anyone could put up with all of your dorkiness-"

And there - Adora laughs, so Catra releases her. "Now come on, princess. If you're going to train, you're going to do it right."

"What, with you?"

"I *was* the best in my year, princess. There's a reason why they agreed to let you be mine."

"Funny - I'm pretty sure you belong to me."

And oh, *oh.* "I guess you're right."

7.

"Catra, can I tell you something?"

Adora's hint of a lisp peeks through, the way it tends to when she's upset or anxious. When Catra looks - *really* looks - she can see how worried Adora looks even if it's probably over something dumb like usual.

"Course, dummy."

Without asking permission, Adora climbs into Catra's bed, curling around her the way they always do. It's not until they're settled - Adora with her head resting on Catra's chest and her tiny fist clenched in Catra's shirt, one of Catra's legs thrown over Adora's and her arm wrapping around Adora's shoulders - that Adora whispers, "Sometimes, I feel weird about you."

With where Adora's head is, Catra is sure she can feel the way her heart stutters in her chest. "What do you mean?"

"Like...I know you. I mean, I *do,* but like I always knew you. Like even before we met."

And *oh,* because- yeah. Yeah. "What are you saying, dork?"

"It feels like we have centuries between us," Adora murmurs. Catra's heart skips a beat again, and Adora ignores it, continues. "Like we've had years upon years of time together. That's why you're so familiar. Because we share part of the same soul."

And maybe it's stupid, maybe she's stupid for believing Adora, but she *does,* because she feels it too. "Like our souls are tied together," and when Adora glances up, startled, Catra glances away. "Shut up."

"No, I-" Adora's laugh is quiet, but genuine. She props herself up on an elbow to look down at Catra, and her gaze is *serious.* "You'd find me, wouldn't you? In our next life?"

"Yeah," Catra manages. Her throat feels dry even after she clears it, and she gives up, speaking around the sudden lump in her throat. "I'll always find you."

8.

Adora *sighs* when she turns the corner and finds Catra standing victorious over a stinking demon corpse. She's bleeding profusely from a wound on her arm, but when Catra turns, all Adora can see is the vicious joy in her eyes and that familiar cheshire grin curving up the corners of her lips. "Hey Adora," her parabatai drawls, "you missed out."

"Come here, idiot," is all Adora says, already reaching for her stele almost on instinct. Catra obeys, holding our her arm, and Adora takes it none-too-gently just to make Catra hiss in annoyance.

"You know," she mumbles as she carefully draws yet another iratze onto her skin, "being so reckless is-"

"Hey. I killed it, that's what matters."

"I know! I just..." and at this point, Adora doesn't even have to say it. She rests one hand over Catra's heart, where the parabatai rune rests, and Catra's gaze softens.

"You don't have to worry about me dying on you, dork. You're stuck with me forever." With one hand she reaches out to cover Adora's hand with her own, and then with a mischievous grin, she smears her bloody hand on Adora's shirt.

"But *that's* for letting me do all the hard work."

"What happened to me missing out?"

"Oh, you did. Now come *on,* Adora, we've got demons to kill."

Adora sighs, but she can feel her parabatai's excitement beginning to bleed into her, and she nods. "Only if I get the next one."

9.

The mermaid's tail is shining gold and her eyes are bluer than the sky on a sunny day, and Catra falls in love immediately. Maybe that's weird, but she can't bring herself to care, not even when the mermaid drapes herself over Catra's surfboard and unbalances her, nearly sending her toppling into the water.

For a long few moments, they regard each other in silence, and then, without thinking, Catra reaches out. It's not until her hand is fully outstretched that she realizes that maybe she shouldn't, but the mermaid just watches her carefully, curiously. Her eyes flutter close when Catra rests her hand on her hair, not quite petting her even if that's all she wants to do.

She wants to say something, *anything,* but she feels like that would break this bubble of a spell, so she doesn't. All she does is not-quite pet the mermaid that is half resting on her surfboard, and fall slowly and headlong in love with her.

10.

The next time Adora goes to Entrapta's, Catra and Scorpia are there too. It's just the two of them - they're bent over their notebooks with a blunt on the table between them; neither of them look up until Adora calls out. Twin lazy grins spread over their lips, and Scorpia pats her leg for Adora to sit in her lap. She does, and - feeling brave, Adora rests her legs over Catra's lap. She's expecting Catra to laugh, or maybe push her off, but instead, Catra reaches out, spreading her hand around Adora's thigh as if trying to see how far around she can reach. It makes Adora's breath catch in her throat, and her gaze locks on Catra's hand, on her fingers as they dance up and up and-

"You wanna smoke too, Adora?"

Thank god for Scorpia, Adora thinks. Catra's wandering fingers freeze, and when Adora meets her gaze, she smiles, a cheshire grin that makes Adora shiver.

She nods.

"You smoke, Adora?"

Adora doesn't know why those three words make her heart race - maybe it's how raspy Catra's voice has gotten, maybe it's the warmth of her hand on her skin and the way she's *looking* at her, like-

"Not really," she stutters out, "I like edibles though."

"Adora's just a baby," Scorpia explains, full of fondness. "It took us almost a year to get her to smoke - she was so scared! And

she's a lightweight too, it's cute." She fishes a lighter from between the couch cushions and lights the blunt for Adora, looking on proudly as she manages one, then two hits.

"Cute," Catra echoes. Adora takes another hit.

11.

"We've always been orbiting each other, don't you think?" Catra mumbles it into Adora's neck, and Adora takes a few moments to process what Catra is saying, what she really means. All the years of dancing around each other as friends, and then as almost-more-than-friends, and then as friends with benefit, and now-

"I'd follow you anywhere, Adora. You know that, right?"

And now Adora's mind wanders to their matching tattoos, to Catra driving across town to comfort her on the worst nights, to their thousandth confession and thousandth kiss (but the first time they meant it like this, as girlfriends, promising today and tomorrow and every day after-)

"You're kind of my sun, you know. My life kind of revolves around you."

And there is so much that Adora could say, but they are beyond words at this point, and it is passed 2am and the only thing on her mind now is I love you, I love you, I love you, so all she does is stretch up to kiss the corner of Catra's mouth.

Catra will understand. She always does.

End Notes

as always, i am on tumblr under the same name
thank you for reading ♡

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